all the strangers came today

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/61690435.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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by tulip_inacup

Summary

Adora used to love Catra so pretty, like the gardenias blooming in the garden down the third corridor of the castle, delicate and pure. She loves her raw and uglier now, holds that truth close to her heart, beating steadily in its harsh edges.

or, Catra gets caught and is taken into Bright Moon for questioning.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

“Hey, Adora.”

The familiar taunting voice did not come as a surprise, although Adora distantly hoped that, restrained and held as prisoner, Catra might not say anything at all. That was, in retrospect, a very silly thing to hope for; she always had something to say.

“Catra.” Adora takes some time to take in the sight of her friend chained and surrounded by pastel pink and purple walls and tries hard not to think about how she was never meant to be captured. Catra was an enemy, now one of the Horde’s leaders, fundamentally opposed to everything Adora stood for and literally against all she swore to protect; she was taken for questioning like any other Horde soldier vulnerable enough to be brought in or unlucky enough to be found by the woods. Everything that happened was coherent and easily explained. And yet.

“Got bored enough of Sparkles to come see me already? Or have they realized I will be of no use to them and just decided to have me killed and get it over with? Oh, man, and they’ll make you do it? Harsh. Some friends you got.”

“No one’s going to kill you!”

“Right, come *on*.” she sounded almost amused, but her slightly arched back and tense stance easily betrayed her mocking tone. Adora sighed, sitting on the ground in a way that put them at the same eye-level, remembering how this always used to be at least a little useful in these situations.

She studied Catra for a bit, but that only seemed to make the girl uncomfortable enough to start talking again. “Well, if this is this place’s prison, I can’t even imagine what the rooms must look like. So this is what you left me for, huh? Pretty pink castles. Who would’ve thought?”

“Catra, how long are we going to keep doing this?” Adora asked, genuinely tired after a night of barely managing to get half an hour of sleep, only to receive a frustrated and irritated glare in

response. “I’ve told you. I never wanted to leave you. I’ve told you every time—“

“Save it, princess. It’s harder to make it sound like you care when you got me in chains to rot.”

“Catra, I am not afraid of you.”

“Because I am pitiful and dirty and weak? I will leave this place, you know.” after pausing and noticing an unusual lack of response from Adora, Catra pressed on, unsatisfied with being unable to get a rise out of her. “And when I do, princess, you will be.”

She looked directly into Adora’s eyes, then, barely realizing how the entirety of her itched for a reaction. She attempted to harden her face in what, she expected, was a stance that would subconsciously provoke an offensive reaction — the knowing smirk and feigned air of apathy that always made Adora’s veins run and pulse with hot blood. She could understand an outburst, a fight, the adrenaline that left no time for one too many thoughts, the urge to lash out and run away and the clarity of the rigid dichotomy between her and whoever she’s against. That was easy, and she could understand.

Adora’s blue eyes, however, in a show of resistance and defiance, met her with a tenderness that seemed to caress her despite its gloom. That, she did not understand. The sorrow in the way she contemplated Catra seemed to tell a tale of a great many woes, yet it did so softly, quietly, almost like the delicate whisper of one who recites a poem of—

“I loved you.”

For one second, Catra barely registered what had been said, willing her mind to jump to potential retorts to what had surely been Adora finally snapping. It wasn't until she noticed Adora's confident attitude and shining posture faltering, as though she was waiting for something, that she realized the words that had been spoken into the almost-darkness of the room.

Suddenly, she held herself very still, her breath shallowing as her entire body seemed to act on its own. Catra felt vulnerable and exposed and it took everything in her not to do something as stupid as cry. She had always been the one to cry from the two of them — when something went wrong, when she was frustrated or angry or sad, feeling particularly more trapped or alone than usual — and Adora had always been the one to take her in her arms and hold her until everything seemed like it could be fine, one day. This time, she would not cry.

"You don't have to say anything. That's not why I'm saying this. I just wanted to tell you. Because it's true. I loved you. So much."

Impulsively, after maybe minutes of just staring back and showing what no doubt was her whole heart in her face, scared and angry over how much power Adora still held over her with just so many words, Catra barely realized the words coming out of her mouth.

"Because I am pitiful and dirty and weak? That was always how you liked your things, serves you right for thinking you can save them."

Catra scarcely remembers what she said seconds after saying it. Adora leaves after that.

Adora did not, in fact, leave her in chains to rot. She supposed she should have done it, really, but could not find it within herself. So instead she would visit the dungeons every single night, with a plate of food and a glass of water, and sit down outside of Catra's cell in what she desperately hoped was companionable silence but was actually silence of the extremely resentful sort. She managed all of six days before she cracked.

"I miss you." she blurted, not unaware of Catra's eyes watching her fidgeting hands. "I don't know what I could have done to make things different, but I wish I had." *And even if I did know now, it wouldn't change a thing, and I'm sorry*, she was about to say, but was interrupted before she could get the words out.

"You could've come back."

"Oh, not this again—" she started, tired, but stopped short when two eyes firmly met her own.

"*No*. Not back for good, Adora, fuck. You could've— that night, you could've come back. And gone all, *wow, Catra, the Horde is evil! We need to do something about it! Not only abusive and manipulative, they're also muder-y! And I may have found a magic sword! So I think I might be leaving, let's change things and blow shit up!*. Did you even consider doing that before writing me off as casualty for the greater good? If Shadow Weaver hadn't sent me to go after your dumb ass, when would I have heard from you again? You just left. You could've cared. You could've come back and told me everything and asked me to come with you."

"Would you have?"

"I don't *know*, Adora. Maybe." she said, and slowly retracted into herself again. "I don't even know why I'm saying this, it's not as if we'll ever find out."

"Yeah." Adora answered, breathily, not really knowing what else she could say then. She wanted to apologize — the words

sounded true, gods, they did — but she just couldn't get her stupid mouth to work. "Guess we won't."

She left again.

Catra was angry and deeply annoyed at being in left in chains to rot, company or not. She supposed she ought to have ignored said company — and its wide pleading eyes — entirely, in fact, but truly could also not find it within herself to do so for long. It was never in her nature to deny Adora the things she wanted, least of all if she asked for it prettily. And so the night visits continued for a couple of days, with increasingly tired silence making itself predominant in detriment of its resentful variant, before Catra cracked.

"Tell me something you miss about the Horde."

You. Adora almost answers, instinctively, but stops herself before igniting something that could lead to confrontation. She doesn't want to fight today. *What makes you think I miss anything about it?* Comes another answer from a defensive corner of her brain, small and angered at realizing how much she really did miss the other woman. She kept that in as well.

"Sparring." She decides, because it's not a lie, despite the fact that it could be a cleaner truth.

"The Rebellion doesn't have sparring?" Catra asks, sounding incredulous.

Adora has to catch herself before she lets out anything about the practices they have started to put up ever since the Horde's attack

on Bright Moon. That's prized information, things she cannot tell Hordak's second in command. The training grounds have been full and buzzing with crackling energy ever since, the eager soldiers separated into different categories for various situations on the battlefield. Adora has been at the forefront of most of these sectors, knowing the enemy's army and strategy enough that she could try her best to teach them how to fight back.

This has given her something to put her energy into, a purpose meaningful enough to drive her mind away from its aimlessly roaming. Having a task at hand has been helpful, but it hasn't been enough. The soldiers are eager to start and quick to learn, but they cannot handle the same routine and push themselves to the same extent that the cadets did back in the Fright Zone; and that's the cadets. Citizens from cities and villages closer to the borders, battling the constant threat of an invasion, neighbor to violence and death, are harder around the edges than those sheltered by the castle walls, but too tender still.

"They spar. It's just not the same as it was back then."

There is a pensive silence before an answer comes. "They're too weak." Catra says then, looking satisfied with herself.

"They're not *weak*." Adora replies, sounding offended on their behalf. "They're some of the strongest people I know." She thinks Catra is going to close off as soon as she says it, but one look at the girl's knowing expression and she knows she's found better bait to bite on.

"But?"

And of course it would be that Catra read right through her. It shouldn't surprise her, but after months of being away from that, the easy transparency glazing the lens through which they see each other, Adora had almost forgotten what it was like. She wonders if she should do this, really; spill her guts out to the enemy about the things that have been bothering her, things that could have destructive potential if Catra decided to weaponize it

along with Hordak, but can't keep the words in when they decide to fall out of her mouth. She's missed having someone who understands.

"They're soft." She says, and there is shame at herself in her words as she voices them. "They're strong and brave and selfless and intelligent but they're just too soft, Catra. They have no discipline, they slack off all the time. When they get tired, they *stop*, instead of going harder. When they're angry, they *relax*. And by relax, I don't mean hitting bags. I mean laying down on cloudy beaches or playing games and not doing anything until they feel better." Catra snorts, and Adora feels a warmth in her chest at knowing she gets it. "There are so many parties. And they're fun, I guess, but also such a waste of time that could be going towards war efforts. And things here are almost ridiculous. There is a waterfall *in my room*."

"A what now?" Catra doesn't even try to conceal the amusement in her voice.

"A *waterfall*. This big water thingy that spills. It's... They wouldn't last a month in Cadet training. Spirits, it sounds awful when I say it out loud, doesn't it? And I mean, it's not like they have to, we shouldn't have had to and it's no one's fault to be lucky enough not to go through *that*. But no matter how much I repeat that to myself— It always looks like a weakness to me."

At this point, she's just venting whatever comes to her mind because it feels so good to be able to. If Catra seems to bristle a bit at times, she hides it fast, so Adora continues. "Do you remember that one time when another squadron joined ours for a month so we could, uh, enhance our training, have our skills assessed when dealing with other soldiers, that kind of thing? Except we were like, thirteen, and none of us had absolutely anything in common with the other group, but we had to live together and it was an absolute mess?" Adora looked expectantly at Catra, who nodded and made a little sound that could almost be laughter but wasn't quite. As soon as she got an affirmation, she kept going, seemingly unable to stop. "I have friends in Bright

Moon. And they're great. But that's— that's how I feel here, sometimes. I just can't seem to fit in with the way they do things."

"You shouldn't." Catra says then, a fire in her eyes that make a hundred different memories rush through Adora's mind, too many and too fast for her to be able to pinpoint just one. "They don't get to make you lose your strength because it intimidates them."

"It's not really about that. And I know you don't believe it, Catra, but they're very strong too. It's just. It's a different kind of strength they have."

"If that's what you think." Catra doesn't look convinced at all, but she just rolls her eyes briefly before continuing. "But that doesn't mean you have to give up yours. Look, maybe we shouldn't have had to endure Shadow Weaver and cadet training, Adora, but we did. And I don't care what they have to say, we're stronger because of it. No one gets to take that from you."

Adora doesn't know what to say to that. Besides, she's been rambling for so long that she feels lightheaded from the weight thrown out of her shoulders, so relaxed that she almost doesn't remember she can't just say whatever she wants to Catra and have them both laugh it off afterwards. So when she shrugs lightly and says, absentmindedly "I thought you said I was weak and stupid." it takes a couple many seconds for the phrase to register and, when it does, she inhales sharply, barely stops herself from bolting upright.

Catra looks taken aback for a moment. Adora's heart beats wildly in her chest until she sees the girl smirk, playfully, edging forward to answer "You still have a long way to go before you're as stupid as people in Bright Moon. Not that that's a big accomplishment. Don't get too excited about it."

But there is no harshness in her tone; afterwards, they almost laugh it off.

Adora is aware that, every morning, Angella sends down warriors and councilors to try and get something out of Catra, as she is aware that, every afternoon, they come up empty-handed. She simply opts not to think too much about it, seeing as Angella has yet to see fit to send her. And so her visits continue for even more days, then, and become longer and louder with each passing night. They talk about silly and serious things, in tones soft but somehow still strained. Catra talks about the cadets they used to train with and the teachers who used to train them, about the Horde and its progressively worsening weather and what the locked rooms they could never enter were actually like inside. She does not mention battle strategies or Shadow Weaver. Adora talks about her new life, the new foods she got to try and the new animals she got to see and the new fabrics she got to feel, what it feels like to take a bubbly bath and what make up is. She does not talk about war councils and the weaponry she is helping them forge.

"Do you ever think about staying?" Adora asks one night over an orange, and suddenly it isn't light chatter anymore.

She braces herself for Catra's reaction, expecting her to distance herself again and lash out. But the girl does neither and, when she speaks, she just sounds sad. "Adora, I can't."

"Why?"

"Because I'm not *you*." she says it like it's obvious. "I'm not She-Ra, big goddess defender of Etherea, whose redemption and trust have been given along with a magic sword. They *hate* me, Adora, I'm a war prisoner, they want me dead. Maybe they might let me live, might even let me stay in exchange for information, under your protection, but that'd just be another place in my life where

I'd be tolerated for your sake, and I can't do that anymore. I *can't*. I'm tired."

Adora wonders briefly if she was ever really like everyone else in the Horde before she quickly decides that's not fair a thought. Because yes, she was — she doesn't think she can ever go a long period of time without reminding herself that the only reason she is here is sheer luck. She could just as easily have been any other Horde cadet who has never found a magic sword and magic powers that came along with a magic destiny.

"Catra..." she doesn't know what she was about to say, doesn't have a chance to find out.

"I miss you too." the admission isn't whispered or mumbled; it sounds firm and sure. It makes Adora's breath catch in her throat. "I miss your stupid face and I haven't slept in a year because of it. But I can't. I know they're evil, Adora, I was never given the chance of not knowing that, but I have friends there who need me, and I don't care if it's selfish, I have things to do and I'm not ready to go back to being no one again. Not yet."

It could be different here. They wouldn't treat you like that. Please, give me a chance to prove you're wrong. There are so many things she wants to say; she wants to take Catra's face between her hands and promise her that everything would work out as long as they're together again. She wants to hug her and say that if Bright Moon doesn't take her in, they'll leave, just the two of them, and win the war themselves with no help from anyone else, because they could. But she says none of those things, because right now it's not her place to.

Instead, she reaches inside the bars just enough that her fingertips lightly reach Catra's wrist, whom she's just noticing is as close to the door as the chains will allow, and tries to trace small lines where their flesh meet. She doesn't say anything, and it seems to be good that she doesn't, because when she ventures just a little bit farther and puts her palm over Catra's, the other girl moves her hands just so that their fingers are interlacing.

When Adora leaves, her throat tight, eyes burning and shoulders heaving the weight of half a dozen lives, she clutches to her uniform shirt regardless, two words echoing with each step forward and resounding with something almost like hope in her ears.

Not yet.

"Tell me about them."

"What?"

"Sparkles and Hearty. Tell me about them."

Adora turns to her, wide-eyed and hesitant, wondering for a second if this is a ploy or a trick that will result in later trouble, thinks about asking *are you sure?* but doesn't. Instead, she smiles big and excited, adjusts her position so that her body is leaning completely towards Catra, and tells her.

Catra is mostly quiet while she rants, smiles briefly, makes noncommittal noises to make sure Adora knows she's listening and tries very hard not to look miserable. She drinks every little detail in carefully and makes a great effort to not drown in this new life Adora has built for herself, wills herself to hide the resentment resurfacing, ignores how she catches herself wanting to be part of it.

Adora is caged in herself, raw and stripped clean of the sword's power, but she burns bright and painful all the same. She looks divine in nature and, even so, there is something tragically fleeting about her. Catra looks at her with something she can't

name — it longs and lingers, but it is neither sadness nor anger; there's a stubborn and defiant contentment in knowing Adora is well, despite everything. It is not that.

There's a melancholy spreading through her body through vines sprouting from the very gaps in-between her ribs; growing seamlessly from the blood in her veins to the marrow of her bones. Catra can feel but not quite distinguish the variations of blue running through her body, tightening around her until everything is almost numb with sorrow.

Catra does not name it.

Catra is decidedly not thinking about the unnamed ache in her chest until the odd hours of the night when she is startled out of her thoughts by the sound of footsteps rhythmically coming down the staircase. She expected Adora for a moment, because the girl had not yet come to visit today, but quickly threw that thought away — their steps didn't sound anything like hers. It could have been a soldier bringing her food and water, but it was too late into the night and, whoever it was, had feet too light for a fighter, floating above the ground, their movement nothing but a faint rustling to Catra's ears. Maybe some princess with wings, that would certainly top the cake.

When the stranger was finally visible in the shimmering moonlight that came from the small windows, Catra did not know what to think. A woman, too white and too tall, strode down the hallway slowly and effortlessly until she stopped right in front of her cell, hands clasped together and hair barely visible from under a soft looking fabric that covered part of her face. It made Catra uneasy,

and she just stared in contemplative silence, waiting for something.

“Force Captain.” the woman said, seeming to be analyzing Catra from where she stood.

She was not greeted in return.

“Word has come to me that the Rebellion has spent quite some time now trying to strike a deal or bargain with you. You have been offered a great many deal of sweet offers in exchange for information, you have been treated very well, they have even allowed that friend of yours to come in here every day even though it never seemed like a prudent decision. The Queen herself has come to talk to you. And it seems that absolutely nothing has made you come to your senses so far.”

“If being chained up to a wall is your definition of being treated very well, I guess. I did not ask for Adora to be sent here. Don’t act like you’re doing me any favors.”

“I would not dare name the atrocities that the Horde has committed against those from the Rebellion, prisoners and civilians alike. Will not speak of the violence inflicted in the war prisoners they have taken from us. The horrors. Yes, Force Captain, we have been kind to you so far. We do not wish to harm you, it gives us no pleasure to hurt. But we have been greatly hurt in the past, and we must protect ourselves so that we will not be hurt in the future. It is a necessity, we do not give ourselves out to die out of luxury.”

So this is what this is about, Catra thinks. This is a war, after all, and she is in no way surprised that they resorted to forceful interrogation. If anything, she is surprised it took them so long.

The woman’s voice is calm and controlled, her demeanor thin and seemingly fragile for all her strong words. Catra wonders what will come of this.

“You take me for weak.” she said, finally, adjusting her position against the wall, the heat in her back so insistent she barely felt it anymore. “You won’t get a word from me.”

Catra couldn’t see much of her features, but she was able to make out the woman’s enraged eyes. The woman rose her hands slowly and, as soon as Catra noticed the movement, a sharp pressure started growing and spreading throughout her head. A sorceress, then. Her breaths turned ragged as the pain grew stronger and memories of flowing black hair and red flickers of light filled her mind.

The woman snapped her fingers. “We will see.”

Catra screams.

“Bow. How do you know you’re in love with someone?”

Adora and Bow rise along with dawn. This is something they discovered rather quickly about one another. This is something about them that fits.

Bow has always enjoyed the feeling of waking up in the sun’s pace. He likes the serene rise and fall of the world’s chest when it’s still asleep. Sometimes he just walks around the castle humming and lost in thought, other times he just lays in his bed and allows himself to bathe in the peacefulness that comes with it. There are days when he starts his training early, days when he goes down to the cities and villages around Bright Moon and chats his way around the street markets just beginning to open and there are days, like this one, where he sits down and just lets

himself play around with things he likes — gadgetry and fabric and whatever new thing he decides to like for the day.

Adora, on the other hand, had never been granted the privilege of choosing the hour in which she'd wake, but had learnt to enjoy hers all the same. Unlike Catra, who would often refuse to get out of bed until the latest possible minute, Adora taught herself how to appreciate the day when it was unguarded and still. The Fright Zone was never quiet or soft — the pipes buzzed every hour of every day, the machinery growled its way into each new second that passed by — but it was never closer to silence than just before the sun rose fully. She enjoyed the small minutes reserved all for herself, liked looking at Catra mere inches away from her just down the bed, the rise and fall of her chest when she was still curled around Adora's leg. She became used to slowly making her way out of their room, the sound of Lonnie's snores and Kyle's restless legs moving against the mattress a soft lullaby accompanying her until the she stepped outside the door, into the sight of a grey sky and the scent of oil that made her think *home.*

In Bright Moon, she remains physically unable to sleep past her usual hour, but finds herself with little to do and see. So she and Bow reached an unspoken agreement: In days like these, she would go to him, and they would stay like that until the rest of the world decided to rise as well.

This is one of those days. The sun has not been floating amongst the clouds for long, the morning still quiet in its early hours — it's maybe a couple minutes later than five o'clock and there is a gentle breeze dancing around the castle coming from the woods. The faint melody of birds chipping in the distance is audible in the tranquil hour and the light is kind where it enters the room through the curtains. There is a calm in the silence hovering just above their heads.

Maybe it's the peacefulness in her chest that makes Adora finally ask it, this comfortable feeling that has taken ahold of her entire being. She is sitting in a fluffy thing on the ground, her legs crossed in a weird angle and head resting against her own arms,

eyes lazily following the dust that drifts in the room where the light catches it as she listens to the faint sound of Bow fiddling with a small electronic device that she has never seen before.

"Uh?" Bow looks up from where he's sitting and stays quiet for a moment, seemingly trying to process what she just said and, as soon as realization hits him, he drops everything in his hands and turns to fully face her. She is suddenly more alert, the spell broken, and can't help the spark of regret that she feels at having said anything. "Can you repeat that?" He asks, wiggling one eyebrow. Adora knows very well he heard her the first time. She wants to punch him.

"How d— You know what? Never mind, forget I said anyth—"

She is already slowly making her way towards the door when Bow, so fast that she wonders if he acquired Glimmer's teleportation powers through proximity alone, holds her back by the arm with an excited glee clear in his face as he pushes her back down in the cushions, cutting her halfway through her sentence.

"No, no, no, no, no. You're not running away from me." He steadies himself on the seat that's just a little too small for him and looks deep into her eyes, almost bursting with excitement. "So, any particular reason you are asking me such hard questions before six in the morning?"

"Bow, come on." She doesn't want to lie, so she just ignores the question altogether. "It's— That's not the kind of conversation we used to have in the Fright Zone. I don't know who else to ask."

"Okay, okay. I'm flattered, just so you know. But I guess this kind of thing can change a lot depending on the person." He starts, slowly and patiently, and Adora gets the distinct impression that he's doing her best to let her know that she can ask and say anything at any given time. Now she wants to hug him. "I mean, if we're talking about every type of love, I love you, and I love Glimmer, but I love each of you in very different ways because

you are different people. Just like you love Glimmer in a very different way than I do, because you and I are very different people, even if we're talking about the same person. You following?"

"Yes." She nods, trying not to feel like the conversation is patronizing.

"Alright. There are some easy clues for knowing if you're generically into someone: butterflies in your stomach when you see them, you take any excuse to be closer, get nervous for no reason, want to kiss them every now and then, that kind of thing." Bow trails off then, looking distractedly at the windows like he's searching for the right words. "But falling in love..."

"Yeah?" Adora calls for him, anxiously, after the silence stretches a second too long.

"I think" he continues "if I had to explain it, is that you know when you love someone because you'd love them even if you knew they didn't love you back. Unconditionally, no questions asked, you know? You love them regardless of what they feel about you, because you don't want to have them, you just want them to be happy. You're content in just loving them. And in having them know that you do."

Adora feels the rhythm in her chest growing deeper and faster throughout Bow's explanation. Maybe her hands are sweating. She's not sure.

"So are you going to tell me who's making She-Ra weak in the knees?"

Suddenly, she feels stupid. Because she knew. She's known she loves her ever since she's been old enough to know what love is, years before she left the Horde and the feeling was given a name. That she would fall for her, too, is just as well. Fate would have nothing less. Adora loves her in the kind of way that doesn't go

away. She's known this for so long, quiet and buried deep in her veins.

Adora used to love Catra so pretty, like the gardenias blooming in the garden down the third corridor of the castle, delicate and pure. She loves her raw and uglier now, holds that truth close to her heart, beating steadily in its harsh edges, and the knowledge feels bittersweet in her tongue.

"Look, you don't have to say anything, yeah? I'm just joking. But this isn't the Horde, I won't be mad at you for falling in love with someone. It's a pretty big deal, and I'm happy for you." Bow sounds so earnest and he seems to be so glad, Adora doesn't know what to do.

She feels her throat closing up and something weighing down in her lungs, a fist closing its fingers around her and strengthening its grip until she aches so much it feels too hard to breathe. She barely notices the tears that have started running down her cheeks until Bow gently wipes them away while saying her name cautiously, his expression turned worried and focused, and she feels a sob run through her whole body. Once the first one comes, she can't stop the second or the third or any after that, and she lets Bow take her in his arms and feels herself shake viciously as she tries not to scream.

They stay like that, embraced by the solitude that the morning grants them, and Adora feels exhausted to her bones when her tears are done falling. There is a weariness enveloping every cell in her body and she thinks that, had Bow not been there holding her together, she probably would have fallen apart. She is so grateful that she feels suffocated by it and she can't lie. She can't lie to him. So she doesn't.

"Catra." Adora finally says and it sounds like a prayer. She says it because she can't say anything else. She meant to make herself sound resilient and strong, but all she manages is to get an unintelligible mumble to go past her lips. She closes her eyes and prepares to be pushed away from his body when she repeats,

louder and clearer this time, “Catra.” and she knows Bow understood it this time.

Instead, she hears a soft “Oh, Adora.” and he holds her even tighter than he had before and she’s helpless to do anything but cry again.

“Force Captain.”

“Come on.” Catra let out, feeling lightheaded and drugged on exhaustion. She vaguely feels the smell of blood, and isn’t sure whether it was scarring from the sorceress’ magic or if she absentmindedly did it to herself at some point. “You’ve been wasting your time since yesterday. I’m no snitch.”

“What is Hordak’s plan? We have information that confirms you have an extremely privileged position on the Horde’s ranks. What does he intend to do next? Ultimately, what’s his goal and next step? What is a weakness we can exploit?” each question is afforded a long pause before the next one comes, meant to leave Catra plenty of time to say something. Minutes pass. She does not.

“Oh, Catra, please.” the woman says, her voice losing the calm demeanor for the first time since she first appeared, startling Catra even in her sickly state. “What do you think will happen? Do you wait for Hordak himself to come to your rescue, because you’re just that special? Because after shining Adora left, they would love you instead, since the only way to make anybody care for you is making it so that the other option is unavailable? I have been in your head for hours, girl. You know it’s true. They won’t come for you. Nobody cares about you. You will be disposed as

soon as that man does not need you anymore. Like you have been before. Like they are to do with you, right now."

Catra feels fever high. The harsh words don't seem to be coming out of the woman's mouth, but etched somewhere deep in her brain, echoing inside her mind and laughing at her. She covers her ears, so desperate in her half-asleep state that her claws end up ravaging most of her face. The voice sounds familiar, deep and with just enough of an edge to sound cruel. From behind her lids she sees a mane of black hair floating through the darkness of her closed eyes, and she wants to scream until Shadow Weaver leaves. She's been here before. She should be over that by now. She's been here before.

"They despise you. You have always been a disappointment to them. The only reason you made it as far as you did is because the one they wanted to fulfill that place was no longer there, and they needed a second best. They don't care for you."

The voices grow louder and the red light grows stronger with each word until Catra doesn't know where she is anymore. She can't breathe over the ringing in her head and memories of punches and broken wrists and bruised arms and neck and cheeks and screams, everything being replayed and etched into her mind for what seems like years. The sharp pain does not subside.

"But that doesn't have to be true here." suddenly, the voice starts to morph into a different one, a newer one, the cacophony of sounds in her head diminishing until all she can hear is a faint lullaby and white noise. There's a dull lilac where the red fades progressively until none of it is left. "You can trust us here. You can recreate your life far away from all those memories and all that pain. We won't judge you here. You can leave, too, if that's what you want. You're free to do what you wish. All you need to do is tell us the Horde's plan."

It seems so easy, too. She feels like she's floating, up in the sky in that weird winged horse she saw once or twice. Nothing feels real and a numbness swirls through her bones to her core. There are

words dancing on her tongue; that one kingdom a little bit too small up the mountains that would grant them the sky, the whispering woods is still weak and dying, it'd be so easy, entrapta, entrapta, the runestones—

"Their next plans, Catra. A weakness. Something. Anything. What is it that you know?" coaxes the pretty sweet voice inside her head. It speaks to her gently, like no one ever did. Maybe Adora, sometimes. Catra thinks she misses that. It seems so easy. She can almost feel herself slipping away, barely manages to get her words out.

"It looks very late for you to be up. You should sleep." Catra's words are mumbled and almost whispered into the night, but they are enough.

The woman snaps her fingers, and Catra screams again.

"Have you been eating? Sleeping? I had to sweet talk one of the guards into letting me in. Wait. Are those bleedings? Catra, have you been hurting yourself?" Adora's voice gains a frantic edge to it, strained as she makes her way closer to the bars until her whole body is pressed against the cold metal separating the two of them. "What happened?" At the lack of response, she lowers herself until her knees hit the ground, slowly reaching out one delicate hand towards the figure leaning against the wall. "Catra, talk to me, please. I won't hurt you."

Catra scoffs, almost quietly, and it's the first sound she makes ever since Adora came in. "Maybe not you personally."

"What is that supposed to mean?"

Catra turns to Adora then, her eyes filled with what looked like an almost forlorn and worn down fury. Irises too tired for ire, but full of anger all the same.

“Who would’ve thought the Rebellion also plays Good Captain, Bad Captain? So much for that higher moral ground you’re always talking about. Although I sure would’ve liked it better if it was you they sent during the night.” She taunted, but her voice was rough and weak and sounded more hurt than anything.

“What do you mean, during the night?”

“Oh, quit playing stupid.” She spit, sounding harsher now, and it only made Adora even more confused.

“Catra, I have no idea what you’re talking about.”

“Do you really know me so little after all these years that you think this little show will work? I invented all your tricky moves. Or, no. This was Sparkles’ idea, wasn’t it? Or maybe the Heart-y guy. You were never the brightest, Adora, but this is just stupid.” for all her bravado, her voice broke halfway through the last words.

Adora was already way past being agitated and, as soon as Catra finished her monologue, it took everything in her power not to scream when she spoke “Catra, what are you talking about?” Her eyes wild and voice desperate as she lunged forward in an unconscious attempt to get closer.

Catra was growing almost beyond the point of rationality with anger until she looked at Adora again and faltered slightly. Adora might seem to be terribly above their past, but Catra knows better, and knows her, and knows when she’s lying and she— she doesn’t look it. “The woman they sent.”

“What woman? Nobody was sent here. That’s why I stopped coming. They wouldn’t let me. It was off-limits for a week.”

“Is that what they told you?”

“They wouldn’t lie to me.”

“But I would?” You have, Adora almost said but did not. She looked at the shadows turned darker underneath Catra’s eyes, the sickly appearance she sported and the small intricate lines of dry unwashed blood staining her body in almost swirling patterns. Adora wanted to touch her, to clean her, she wanted to hug her, too, for some reason.

“Are you really saying the truth?” a scoff. “What did she do?” At that, she was met with nothing but silence. “Catra, please, what did she do to you?”

“Don’t you think I have been asked enough questions in this place by now?” she snapped, folding in on herself, but she looked ashamed. “Go ask them! I’m not the one who did anything!”

“Adora! I’ve been looking for you everywhere. Look, remember what you said about how you were about to follow the signal to some piece of First Ones tech until it suddenly vanished from the map? Bow has been trying to find a way to try and trace the moving energy, and he thinks he might be close to it. Wanna go check out?”

“That sounds great! I’m just, in the middle of something right now, do you think maybe tomorrow?” Adora was apologetically extricating herself from the situation when suddenly, already far down the corridor, staring at her friend’s back, she realized she could try something. Her chances of getting through her friend were bigger than through the queen, after all. “Glimmer?”

“Yeah?”

“Do you know—“ a pause. “Do you know anything about some woman visiting Catra?”

The small purple silhouette stayed very still for maybe two seconds, before turning with an unnatural sounding twinkling laugh, eyes just a little bit too wide. “What? Hasn’t her cell been closed off for the last week?”

The two seconds were enough.

“You know something.” Adora stepped closer, looking carefully at the princess’ face for any new sign of deceptions.

“What?” Glimmer asked again, but her voice had a high pitch to it that even Kyle could have noticed. She sighed at the sight of Adora’s raised eyebrow, suddenly looking like she was about to start trembling. “Adora, I am so sorry, I never wanted to lie to you, it was so hard keeping it in for an entire week, but the council determined we could not say a word of it to you. I think there had been people watching, too. They said you wouldn’t let them carry on with the questioning, that it wouldn’t have worked out and would have compromised the operation. That this was too big a deal to mess up. I was afraid that if I said something they would do something even worse to her, because then there’d be nothing to lose. I am so sorry. You know I don't like her, but I should never have lied to you.”

Adora was stuck in place. She wanted to comfort Glimmer, to hug her out and said it hadn’t been her fault, but couldn’t find it in her right at that moment, too drowned in her feelings of betrayal and worry and *catra catra catra*. Instead, she placed her hand gently in the smaller girl’s shoulder, hoping that could be enough to appease her guilt for now, and squeezed lightly before asking as friendly as she could “Who was the woman?”

“They didn’t really say much to me. It was a sorceress from Mystacor, just angry enough, I think. She went there for questioning, but apparently didn’t get anything, I mean, *anything*,

in a week, so they gave up on it. I am so sorry. I should have said something."

"It's ok, Glimmer. It wasn't up to you. Don't do it again, yeah? I want us to trust each other."

"Yeah. I promise."

"Ok. I promise, too."

Adora has heard that one too many times.

"I came here, all those months ago, to join your cause, because I found out the Horde was evil. Yes, I was lost and looking for answers, I was feeling betrayed and confused, but at the end, I only came because I wanted to do good. I didn't want to be with people responsible for destruction and pain. I wanted to help people, to protect them. I didn't come here so y— we would torture our prisoners until we got them to talk. How does that make the Rebellion any better than the Horde?"

"Adora, I do not understand. You, my daughter and Bow have done great things for the Rebellion in the last year. The three of you have been responsible and committed. Do you think you have been playing a game all this time?" The Queen does not sound unkind, but looks unyielding, if a little surprised. "This is a war. I understand that, due to your past, the lines are not as clear and distinct to you as they are to the rest of Bright Moon, but we have an enemy and a goal. Right now, we have one of the strongest fighters and highest ranked officials of the enemy's army sitting in a prison cell, holding information that could be decisive

concerning where we're headed, and you expect us to let her go with empty hands because she is stubborn?"

Adora looks up at her, rightful indignation still visible in her face but not as fierce as moments ago. Her angry and resolve remain, but now she also looks exhausted, and a little bit lost.

"I know she was your friend." Angella says, then, softening her voice and resting her hand on Adora's shoulder. "But we have been losing territory in the mountains and this is the first time in years that we have an alliance amongst more than half of the resisting kingdoms. We do not have the privilege of letting go of a chance of having the upper hand. I understand this is hard. But war is not won without sacrifices." her gaze becomes distant and glazed, staring at something beyond the walls of the throne room. "I would know."

Adora wants to scream. But she just leaves, frustrated and trying to think of a new way to do something.

After a long hour of asking many people roaming around the castle where she could find the Army's main commanding officer, Adora finds herself standing in front of the stables. The sun is starting to set, its orange rays painting the skies in striking colors and lines, strangely fitting with the brown ceiling and straw-filled floor.

Ever since Swift Wind decided to dedicate the majority of his time to freeing all the other horses, most of the animals started to spend the day roaming around the green fields surrounding the castle, only coming back to the stables around nighttime for rest, as per decided by an agreement made with the Council. Swift

Wind remains unsatisfied, but it was enough for him to consider it a start. The horses are still called in when requested by the soldiers, though, which is why Adora is here.

As she steps inside, she doesn't have to venture too far into the construction before movement rapidly catches her eye. Inside one of the stalls, an imposing black horse stands tall alongside with a strong and equally regal woman, who appears to be grooming him. Adora supposed the woman has already noticed her, but the stranger remains dutifully quiet, not even glancing in her direction.

"Hello." She steps closer and gives a small smile, forwarding her hand so the other woman could take it. "I don't believe we have ever talked outside of strategy meetings. I'm Adora."

The woman almost snorts, turning fully towards Adora as soon as she realizes she's being spoken to and taking her hand in a firm handshake. "I know. It's a pleasure to meet proper'. I'm Amaya."

Despite her light tone, there is respect and even glee in Amaya's eyes when she nods, and Adora suddenly dares to feel a little confident that this might work. She decides to ease into it. "So... Are you planning on riding today?"

"You came all the way to the stables to ask me if I plan on riding today?"

Smooth. Scratch that, she tried and failed to ease into it. Better just to gamble on luck.

"We need to talk. It's important."

At the seriousness in her tone, Amaya quickly sobers and her expression becomes focused. She hums in agreement before walking all the way out the stables without a word. Adora starts to think she really left and doesn't plan to come back until she resurges from the door guiding an almost-yellow looking horse that follows her obediently. "Freya doesn't talk or have wings, but I'm sure you'll get along great. We can talk while we ride." she

said simply and directly, moving towards her own horse, only stopping briefly midway through her path to lean slightly towards Adora and whisper, carefully. “Harder for anyone to hear us.”

Adora finds she likes her just fine.

They have been riding steadily for a couple minutes when Adora decides to break the silence. “Have you heard about the prisoner that has been captured recently? In battle?”

“The Horde commander, yea?” Amaya doesn’t seem startled by the sudden inquiry, expression neutral and voice conversational. “Magicat.”

“That’s the one.” Adora agrees. She stops herself for a moment, taking a steadying breath and attempting to maintain her voice even when she says, “They have been torturing her to get intel on the Horde.”

She keeps looking forward for a couple seconds, resisting the urge to close her eyes, before she finds it in herself to avert her gaze back to the woman standing next to her, expecting denial and disbelief. Instead, Amaya has a raised eyebrow and an almost confused look on her face. “Yes.”

“I swea— Wait. Yes?”

“I mean, yes, I know. What did you expect?”

“What did I expect? I expected us to be better.” Adora gestures wildly and is barely aware that she’s brought her horse to a halt as she speaks. “I thought our job was to protect people, to help them, not to throw them in prison cells and hurt them when they’re powerless to fight back. That’s cowardly and wrong. There are other ways to get through someone, better ways, and we don’t have to be like them. I expected the Rebellion to be fair and just. I— I expected you to help me.” It sounds so much like a plea, Adora has to refrain herself from wincing.

Now that Adora thinks about it, she wasn't even sure what exactly she came here to ask for in her desperate. Someone to back her up when she defended Catra in the inevitable Council meeting that was sure to come up soon? An ally in thinking new ways to get them to strike a deal? A hand willing to help her break Catra out of Bright Moon?

"You are an idealist, She-Ra." the woman says, serious, looking her fully in the eyes, and Adora vaguely thinks this is how she must talk to the foot-soldiers just before battle. Her tone is no longer mocking or playful — she sounds firm and hard and strong. "As is the Queen's daughter, and her friend, and the late King. It's a beautiful trait, and one we need. Revolutions are not made without idealists, She-Ra, but they are not won with them alone."

At that, she turns her back on Adora, lightly tapping her horse so it would keep going. She turns her head briefly as she moves further and further away, and her eyes are softer again. "I believe in you. And your ideals. But my job is to make sure that we'll be strong enough to spread 'em. I cannot help you. I hope you understand."

"I don't know what to do." Adora said, sounding defeated. Three heartbeats passed before she rose her lowered head with a start, shocked and scared, all wide-eyes that didn't really see anything. "I have no idea what to do." She repeated, slowly, incredulously, and the realization seemed to frighten her so.

"Adora, come on, breathe." Glimmer appeared on her side, just distant enough that Adora still had enough space to calm herself down and move away if she wished to.

“No, Glimmer, I—“ Adora’s hands reached for her own face and stayed there, seemingly out of her control. “I have spoken with you and Bow. I have gone to the Queen and the General. I thought I’d get someone to listen, but nobody... And I don’t know this place enough that I could... I can’t think of anyone else that... There’s nothing I can do to help...” Her unfinished phrases abruptly stopped when Glimmer touched her arm gently and, seeing Adora seemed comfortable with the action, enveloped her in a hug.

Adora remained still for two beats until she held Glimmer back in a clumsy embrace and did everything in her power not to cry.

“I have to tell you something.”

A raised eyebrow and tilted head. “Go on.”

“Look, I wasn’t going to say anything because I didn’t want you to worry.” Adora bit her lip, closed her eyes briefly before continuing. “And you don’t have to. We’ll figure something out, I just— We promised no more lies. So I won’t lie. I have been trying to do something, anything, I’m not sure what. But I have been trying to figure something out for the past days and I just. I haven’t. I couldn’t. Catra, I couldn’t help at all, and I’m sorry.” The words come out a little too fast, a little too harsh, a little too incoherent, and Adora is not used to this anymore.

When she looks up again, there is a strange emotion passing through Catra’s face, but it’s gone as soon as it came. Still, there is a tenderness in the midst of the many feelings running through her eyes, and when she speaks, it’s not angry or unkind, “I know

she made it seem like I'm your responsibility, Adora, but I'm really not."

"What are you talking about?"

"I—" Catra started, both quiet and exasperated, but shook her head and started over. "Shadow Weaver. I know she was always talking about how you were the only reason I was still around, and a nuisance, and you think you have to keep me on a leash to protect me from her, and from everything else, but that's not true. You don't have to worry about keeping me in line. I'm not under your protection, I don't need it, Adora. It's... My fuck ups are my own. You don't have to fix them."

Adora looked at her for a long moment, taking in everything Catra had just said, and realized it was true. Maybe it wasn't the whole truth — she feels responsible because she cares about Catra. But that's not all of it, and she knows it deep in her heart that it's not. "You're right." she said then, because it's important to learn how to say it to her again.

The silence stretches for some time, full of unspoken things Adora wants to say but decides against. But she can't hold everything in and, just before walking out, she heaves a sigh and whispers into the darkness between the two of them. "Catra? I know you don't need it. I do. I wish you'd stop trying to prove that."

"Right. Thank you. For trying to help."

She looked at Catra, something about her still so big and so strong even when she is small and weak. She looks at her, in that prison cell, and then she looks at the cell, and the bars, and the tiny keyhole in the left corner that seemed to twinkle just for her eyes, like it wanted her to look, and she knew, instinctively, deeply, with the certainty possessed only by rocks and animals and mountains, what it was that she was going to do.

“Adora.”

“Yeah?” she answered, feeling a thin layer of tears already covering her eyes. Catra looked briefly down the hall towards the window she was moments away from plunging into and falling away through the night. Then she took a shuddering breath and one step forward, then two, now close enough that Adora could briefly feel her breathing.

Catra gently laid one hand just on the side of her neck, fingers tracing patterns lightly into Adora’s skin. Adora could not breathe — she felt as if experiencing something divine under the feeling of the other girl’s fingertips. Catra’s gaze lowered just enough that she was staring at her lips through half-lidded eyes, her own parted just so and Adora thinks she looks like she’d taste sweet, like one of those foods Glimmer and Bow always insist on showing her, each better than the last, hot and sugary and soft.

Catra pulls her in softly, barely using any strength at all, and Adora allows herself to be pulled closer, keeps going even when Catra stops, until their lips meet. She doesn’t really know what to do, then, so she just moves them slowly and with a little pressure and tries to control the heat in her belly as she tangles her hand amongst Catra’s curls, tugging gently, devouring the sound that leaves the girl’s lips as she does so.

Adora thinks about walking one or two steps forward until she has Catra pressed against the castle walls, open and willing and hers. About taking her to that too big room of hers, not a care in the world about the Queen or the Rebellion, and just keep doing whatever makes her feel good all night long. Adora thinks about being able to sleep after almost a year of endless white nights, about tracing featherlight fingers through Catra’s features when she still hasn’t awaken and about holding each other until they feel safe. Adora thinks about asking her to stay, stay today and

tomorrow and every day after that, to never leave again. But she doesn't.

Instead, she weakly bites the lips pressed against her own, moves away just enough to take in the sight of Catra, alight with moonlight and stardust shine, a smile painted in her lips. She looks alive with bristling magic. Adora is filled to the brim with something she can't name.

"I loved you, too." Catra says, allowing for the early hours to eat her words whole and carry its remains along with the soft breeze of a world that's still asleep. And she leaves. And does not look back.

End Notes

so, that was that. i wrote this back in 2018 when i first started watching the show but never really came around to finishing it. this week i stumbled upon it again while i was cleaning out my notes (end of the year rituals and whatnot) and noticed that it was almost a fully fledged out fic so i figured, you know, why not. if you thought it was a little clipped, that's probably why. anyway, i hope someone enjoys it. english is not my first language and i was sixteen when i wrote this, so i apologize for any mistakes or any, you know, silliness in general. rereading it i thought i'd do everything differently if i were to write it today, but isn't that always the case? happy holidays!

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